

Coming to the GSB

An Unofficial
GSB Guide for
International
Students

Brought to you by the
GSB Student Association
International Committee

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Part I – Welcome!

Welcome to the GSB!

We are very excited to welcome you and look forward to meeting you on campus in September. As international students, moving to the US and settling in can be a hassle – we know this because we went through the same process. We want to help you make your life a little easier.

As the GSB Student Association's International Committee, we are here to represent the interests of international students at the GSB (you!). Please don't hesitate to reach out in case of any doubts, questions, ideas or if you need a helping hand. It's our pleasure! And remember that anyone at the GSB will be happy to get to know you and help you out.

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Also, make sure to join the GSB International Students 2027/2028 WhatsApp Group:
<https://chat.whatsapp.com/KTXzxfBx2Pp9Ptv6wRTg3S>

This unofficial guide was produced by the current GSB Student Association's International Committee, building on the work of past committee members, and contains information shared by current and previous GSB international students. We encourage you to use this guide to get a feel for the tasks at hand and some possible solutions that previous students have tried in your place. **Use it as a suggestion and supplemental reference as you do your own research.**

Important Disclaimer:

Please note that this is an unofficial guide and it is not meant to be a comprehensive checklist. It is your responsibility to make sure you do not miss any deadlines and complete all necessary paperwork. Additionally, many providers or vendors are suggested here based on what other students have done in the past, **yet these vendors are not in any way endorsed by us.** You have to ultimately make your own choices. Please note that **we cannot answer any questions relating to visa or taxes** – please direct those questions to the Bechtel International Center. **We cannot give any legal / visa / immigration advice either,** and any information provided is a suggestion based on past student's experience and may or may not apply to you. We have made an effort to present updated and correct information here as of the date of publication, but we cannot guarantee it and **it is your responsibility to check from the corresponding sources** before making your own decisions.

We Strongly Recommend That You:

- Keep track of information on MyGSB Digest (official weekly emails from GSB; **very important!**)
- Thoroughly read the MyGSB admit section at mygsb.stanford.edu
- Refer to Bechtel International Center for visa and immigration related issues (they are THE official counselors on this matter). Go to bechtel.stanford.edu or email them at internationalstudents@stanford.edu.

If you find any information within that is out of date or incorrect, or you have any suggestions of additional information that should be included for future GSB students, please let us know by e-mailing GSB_sainternationalcommittee@stanford.edu or any of the committee members listed above.

That said, we hope this (unofficial) guide is helpful for logistical and settling issues. We can't wait to see you on campus.

Enjoy!

GSB SA International Committee

Part II – Before Coming to the GSB

Here are a few things you should know about, and plan for, before coming to the GSB. For logistics once you arrive at the GSB, see Part III – After Coming to the GSB.

1. Packing and Shipping

Here are some general thoughts to consider:

- Pack primarily stuff that's expensive or that you can't easily replace or that you need right when you arrive.
 - Personal memorabilia like photos or decorations.
 - Clothes
 - Your favorite clothes. The dress code at GSB is very chill. Wear what you feel most comfortable in, whether that's a T-shirt or shirt, trousers, shorts, athleisure, or even more casual.
 - Formal outfits for future work interviews but also formal GSB parties like GSB Gala, GSB Show, GSB Prom.
 - You should also bring your favorite dresses for these special events:
 - Halloween - Fall quarter
 - Vegas FOAM (sparkly dresses - think 70s disco vibes) - Winter quarter
 - GSB Winter formal, GSB Gala, GSB Prom (formal think long gowns/3-piece suits/tuxedos) - Winter and Spring quarters
 - National and other costumes (lots of cultural events and costume parties at the GSB).
 - Despite all the sunny pictures on the brochures, it can get cold in Palo Alto: pack some sweaters and warm coats.
 - For folks coming from tropical/temperate climates, suggest packing more winter clothes than you think you need
 - Medication: A refill of any prescriptions you may need upon arrival to campus, so that you don't have to rush to a pharmacy right away. Getting an eye prescription on paper would also be helpful, as eye exams can be very expensive in the US. In general, if you think you want to get any medical test/treatment done, try to get it done back at home as healthcare in the US is expensive and complex. However, if you get Cardinal Care (Stanford's default insurance plan - see more in section [4.2. Health Insurance](#)), you get a free eye exam and health checkup every policy year.
 - Sports equipment: Skiing in Tahoe is a common pastime here, you can surf in Santa Cruz, biking/hiking in the redwood hills above campus, and the campus hosts the widest range of sports infrastructure imaginable - think all kinds of racquet sports, golf, swimming, etc. Although you can buy stuff from Amazon or rent everything at / around the campus, you can bring some stuff that you really like - think your favorite gear!
 - Electronics: Bring at least two US-mains adapters so you can charge/use your

laptop/mobile phone as soon as you arrive. Recommended to buy universal adapters for international travels. The US power is 110V; most electronics (laptop, phone) are compatible with 110V and 220V. Certain hair dryers only work with either 110V or 220V.

- Bring some US\$ cash for your first few days (\$200-300 is usually sufficient). You may need cash for tips, small purchases, or situations where card payments don't work.
- If you have a multi-currency debit card from your home bank (e.g., HSBC, Citibank, DBS), it can also help as a temporary means of payment.
- Check information on your specific housing situation to see what is included in your furnished or unfurnished apartment. Most on-campus housing is fairly small, so think carefully about what you bring!
- Some Residences might accept packages before you arrive (the GSB residences do, but only a few days before), some others will not, and the dates will vary; so make sure you contact the proper residence to understand policies from which date they accept packages or for any other questions.
- In most cases you will not have linens and towels you might need for Day 1. Consider ordering them online and having them delivered to your dorm, or bringing one set. Many of us ordered basics from IKEA/Target/Walmart/Amazon.
- Shipping with UPS/Fedex/DHL can be expensive. Check with some major airlines in your area to see if they have cargo divisions (e.g. Lufthansa Cargo, Delta Cargo).
- If you know any MBA2s or California-based MBA1s / friends, ask if they would be willing to accept your boxes. Otherwise, send us an email or message us on Slack and we'll see if we can help!
- If you do forget things, don't worry - you can purchase most things online or around campus. Plus, your Stanford email gives you 6 months of Amazon Prime membership for free!
 - Target and Walmart also have student discounts when you arrive on your first / first few orders - do leverage them!

2. Preparing for Arrival

Whether or not you plan to attend the Stanford Summer Session (English for Foreign Students), one of the Stanford Graduate Summer Institute (free) courses, we advise you to get here early! Week Zero will be a lot of school/administrative work and social events, so it is advisable to get on campus early (2-3 days is sufficient) to set up your apartment and necessities. Here are a few tips:

2.1 Entering the US

Never forget to carry your signed I-20 or DS-2019 and passport when entering/leaving the US. Once you have entered the U.S., make sure when you travel abroad that your I-20 or DS-2019 is properly endorsed for travel abroad. The signature is on page 3 and should be valid for a year. It is important to check especially between the 2 years as most students will be traveling (GST / GMIX / leisure) around the time when the initial signature usually expires. Have it renewed by Bechtel before leaving campus. But don't worry about it now, Bechtel will remind you. More information on this [page](#).

Global entry (and TSA pre-check): You can apply for Global Entry before you arrive in the US. Global

Entry is a U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) program that gives you expedited clearance through immigration when entering the United States, and it automatically includes TSA PreCheck, which lets you go through faster domestic security lines (considerably lower wait times; no need to remove shoes, laptops, liquids, or belts).

Global Entry costs \$120 for a 5-year membership. Citizens of the following countries are currently eligible: Argentina, Australia, Brazil, Colombia, Germany, India, Panama, Singapore, South Korea, Switzerland, and the United Kingdom. U.S. citizens and lawful permanent residents are also eligible, regardless of their country of birth.

Important: TSA PreCheck on its own is only available to U.S. citizens and lawful permanent residents. As an international student on an F-1 or J-1 visa, you cannot apply for standalone TSA PreCheck. However, if your country is on the Global Entry list above, you can apply for Global Entry, which automatically includes TSA PreCheck.

How to apply:

1. Create an account on the Trusted Traveler Programs (TTP) website: <https://ttp.dhs.gov>
2. Submit your application and pay the \$120 fee (non-refundable, even if denied).
3. Some countries (notably India) require additional background verification by their home government, which can take 6 months to a year. Indian citizens should apply as early as possible.
4. Once conditionally approved, schedule an in-person interview at a Global Entry Enrollment Center. SFO has an enrollment center, and you can also complete your interview through "Enrollment on Arrival" at participating airports when you first land in the US.
5. Many premium credit cards (e.g., Chase Sapphire Reserve, Amex Platinum) reimburse the \$120 application fee. If you have one of these cards, use it to pay.

Even if the approval takes a while, it is worth starting the process now. You will be flying domestically a lot during your MBA (conferences, interviews, GSTs, personal travel), and TSA PreCheck alone will save you hours over two years.

2.2 Getting to campus and around

Option 1: Uber / Lyft. If you haven't done so already, download these apps! You will be using them constantly. The fare from SFO to campus will range from \$50-\$100 (depending on surge pricing at the time of use) and takes ~30 min (or up to an hour during rush hour). Ridesharing options within these apps (UberX Share, Lyft Shared) can reduce the cost.

SFO rideshare pickup directions (as of 2025-26):

- **Domestic Terminals 1, 2, 3:** Rideshare pickups are on the 5th floor of the central parking garage. Follow signs for "Rideshare / TNC" after baggage claim.
- **International Terminal:** Rideshare pickups are on the curb outside the International Terminal entrance on the Departures level.

The pickup locations at SFO can feel confusing on your first visit. Just follow signs that say "Rideshare" or

"Uber/Lyft" and avoid signs that say "Taxis."

Option 2: BART & Caltrain. The cheapest option is to use public transport, but beware, this will be extremely rough if you have suitcases with you and will take over an hour! You will need a [clipper card](#) to travel on Bay Area's public transport. The easiest way is to add a Clipper card directly to your Apple Wallet or Google Pay through the Clipper app (physical cards are being phased out). From SFO, take the Bay Area Rapid Transit (BART) train to Millbrae, then transfer to Caltrain southbound to the Palo Alto station. If you fly into San Jose International Airport (SJC), check current VTA bus routes to the nearest Caltrain station (routes change periodically; Google Maps transit directions are your best bet), then take Caltrain northbound to Palo Alto. From the Palo Alto Caltrain station, take an Uber/Lyft or the free Marguerite Shuttle to get to campus (~10 minutes). The Marguerite is a free bus system (see details in the [Transportation on Campus](#) section below) that runs around campus; just hop on, no ID or fare needed.

2.3 Accommodation

If you're coming to Stanford before your housing contract starts, check AirBnB [Palo Alto Vacation Rentals | Airbnb](#) for places to stay.

2.4. Visa and Immigration Preparation

This guide does not provide immigration advice (please direct all visa questions to Bechtel International Center). Here are some basic key steps every international students need to be aware of:

- **I-20 or DS-2019:** After you accept your offer and submit proof of financial support, Stanford will issue your I-20 (for F-1 visa) or DS-2019 (for J-1 visa). You need this document to apply for your visa.
- **SEVIS Fee:** Pay the I-901 SEVIS fee (\$350 for F-1, \$220 for J-1) at <https://www.fmjfee.com> before your visa interview. Keep the receipt.
- **Visa Interview:** Schedule a visa interview at the US Embassy or Consulate in your country as early as possible. Summer appointments fill up fast. Bring your I-20/DS-2019, SEVIS fee receipt, passport, admission letter, financial documents, and any other supporting materials.
- **SEVIS Transfer:** If you are already in the US on a different I-20 (e.g., from a prior degree), you will need to transfer your SEVIS record to Stanford. Contact Bechtel International Center to initiate this process. The transfer must be completed before you can enroll.

For detailed, up-to-date visa guidance, refer to Bechtel International Center:

<https://bechtel.stanford.edu/immigration/new-students>.

3. Housing

GSB students live in various on-campus housing as well as off-campus homes. The most common on-campus options include Schwab, Jack McDonald Hall, Escondido Village (which also includes EVGR), Munger and Oakcreek. There is also an expanding variety of subsidized off-campus options. Note that official university housing information about moving in will be on the Admit Tab of MyGSB.

Other information including contacts for housing front desks can be found at the Student Housing website here: <https://rde.stanford.edu/studenthousing/>

Below are a few general tips on housing:

- Really don't worry if you didn't get into the GSB Residences (i.e., Schwab and Jack McDonald Hall), or any of the other major on-campus residences - you'll still have access to all social activities. You can still use GSB Residences' study rooms and other amenities.
- A good share of students prefers not to live in GSB Residences (Schwab and Jack McDonald Hall) as a way to find some fresh air outside GSB life. Others simply can't live in GSB Residences because they live with their significant others ("SO"), or have kids (there is a limited number of couple housings available in the GSB Residences). Other students just want to have larger spaces, or save some money in exchange for a slightly longer walk (think 10-15 minutes) or a bike ride - there is no right formula.
- If you're living in Munger, EV, EVGR or Rains (or any other university housing), you should have a CA (Community Associate) assigned to you. A CA is a returning Stanford student who helps to build the community in a residential area and can help you with your transition. Ask them any questions about housing, moving-in etc. Information on CAs will be typically provided to students when they pick up the keys to their on-campus apartment/room.

3.1. Quick Housing Comparison

To help you think through the trade-offs, here is a brief summary of the main housing options students use. Note that official details, pricing, and availability change each year, so check the R&DE website (<https://rde.stanford.edu/studenthousing/>) for the latest information.

- **Schwab and Jack McDonald Hall (GSB Residences):** Closest to the GSB (literally next door). Single rooms with shared kitchens (you get assigned a "kitchenmate"). Highly social, easy to pop into study rooms and common areas. Rooms are small. Best for: students who want maximum immersion in GSB social life.
- **Escondido Village (EV) Mid-Rises:** About a 10-15 minute walk or 5-minute bike ride to the GSB. Only available to couples without children; 1-bedrooms available. Roughly 450-500 sq ft. In-building laundry. Best for: couples who want space and independence.
- **EV Low-Rises:** Slightly larger than mid-rises, but laundry facilities may require a walk. Similar commute to GSB. Usually prioritized for couples with children, a few are available to couples without children and very few for single students. Best for: couples or students with pets who want a bit more room.
- **EV Studios:** Part of the EV complex. Available to couples without children and single students.
- **EVGR (Escondido Village Graduate Residences):** Newer buildings, includes EVGR High-Rise, Mid-Rise, and Kennedy Residence. Modern amenities, marketplace on-site. ~5-10 minute walk to the GSB, depending on which building you are in. Best for: students who prefer newer buildings and don't mind a slightly longer commute.
- **Munger:** Large graduate student community, close to Arrillaga Dining Commons, ~15 mins walk from the GSB. Has its own social ecosystem. Best for: students who want to mix with non-GSB

graduate students.

- **Oak Creek:** Off-campus subsidized housing, about 10-15 minutes by car. Quieter, more suburban feel. Best for: students with families or who want a break from campus life.
- **Off-campus (private rental):** Some students rent in Palo Alto, Menlo Park, or Mountain View. More expensive but more independence. Best for: students with specific needs or partners who work locally.

Don't stress about your housing assignment. Students in every housing option make great friends and have excellent experiences. The GSB social life is centered at the Knight Management Center and the Residences common areas, which are accessible to everyone regardless of where you live.

3.2. Pets on Campus

If you are bringing a pet (dog, cat, etc.), check the pet policy for your specific housing assignment. GSB Residences (Schwab and JMac) allow pets in some units. EV and EVGR also allow pets in certain buildings. You may need to register your pet and pay a pet deposit. For dogs, campus is very dog-friendly with plenty of green space. For doggie daycare and dog walkers, ask other pet owners on Slack. Keep in mind that some pre-orientation trips (like Tahoe) will require you to make arrangements for your pet.

4. Vaccinations and Health Insurance

4.1 Vaccinations

Since immunization requirements at birth differ for each country, get (i) any required vaccination and (ii) an English translation of your immunization record at a hospital in your home country before coming to the GSB.

Note that Stanford requires all students to have 2 MMR vaccinations given after their first birthday and at least 28 days apart. Plan ahead if you have to get vaccinated. If your record shows that you need tuberculosis testing, you can take the test at your home country or the Vaden Health Center. Make sure you make an appointment. You need these two - MMR vaccine proof and a TB test to enroll at the University so we recommend you plan ahead and keep an eye out for emails from Vaden on this.

Address: Vaden Health Center, 866 Campus Drive, Stanford, CA 94305, Directions: [Stanford Searchable Map](#). Appointment: (650) 498-2336

4.2 Health Insurance

Students:

All students (international and domestic) are automatically enrolled in the Cardinal Care health insurance plan. The annual premium for 2026-2027 is \$8,808 (\$734/month), running from September 1 through August 31. It is classified as a "Platinum" plan under the ACA, meaning very high coverage with low out-of-pocket costs at the time of care (e.g., \$50-\$100 ER copays, \$0 copays for diagnostic labs and X-rays). If you would like to waive Cardinal Care, you must do so by early-September (check the exact deadline in GSB Digest and MyGSB communications; the Health office makes no exceptions). Waiving

requires proof that you have alternative insurance meeting Stanford's minimum standards. More information about Cardinal Care can be found on Vaden's website under the Student Health Matters section: <https://vaden.stanford.edu/>

Since Cardinal Care is so expensive (~\$9k per annum), a good number of international students purchase insurance from other healthcare providers such as ISO, Wellaway, and PSI (\$1-3K per annum). Make sure you choose an insurance plan that meets Stanford's standards (quick heads up: many explicitly exclude skiing as a covered activity, so if you're keen to hit the Tahoe slopes, it may be worthwhile to look into the fine print here - every year people get injured skiing), so that you can get the Cardinal Care waiver. Also confirm that the plan includes emergency medical evacuation and repatriation coverage, which Stanford requires for international students. The insurance companies can typically help you verify and fill out the necessary form. If you waive Cardinal Care, you can still access Vaden Health Center for basic services, but billing and coverage will work differently. Check with Vaden for specifics.

We recommend uploading the insurance brochures to your favorite AI assistant to understand the fine print as well as various terms (such as copay, deductibles, co-insurance, OOP max, etc.) associated with health insurance.

To waive Cardinal Care, be careful with the deadlines to meet. The Health office will make no exceptions. Please reach out to Vaden for the necessary forms you might need to complete.

Dependents:

Dependents can also sign up to Stanford sponsored health insurance, yet the costs and benefits differ from those of students. It is called the Stanford Student Dependent Health Insurance Plan, and can be opted into (vs. students that can opt out of) when the student first matriculates at Stanford. This is the one and only time during the entire academic career at Stanford when a student can purchase the plan for his/her dependent(s) unless a qualifying life event occurs. More information can be found on the Vaden Health Center website.

5. Pre-Orientation Trips

Before classes start, there are several optional pre-orientation trips that are a great way to bond with classmates. These typically include:

- **Tahoe Trip:** A weekend trip to Lake Tahoe organized by MBA2s, usually held the weekend before move-in (early September). This is by far the most popular pre-orientation event. Logistics and sign-up details will be shared on Slack and WhatsApp over the summer.
- **Colombia Trip:** A multi-day trip to Colombia organized by students, usually in late August. Very popular and a great way to build friendships before school starts.
- **Yacht Week:** An optional trip (typically in Croatia or Greece) over the summer with HBS folks. Think a week of partying on a yacht + beaches. More expensive, but a memorable experience for those who attend.
- **Summer GSTs (Global Study Trips):** Some GSTs take place over the summer before school starts. These are academic trips organized by the GSB with a mix of company visits and cultural

experiences.

For international students: If you are on an F-1 visa and plan to travel outside the US between these trips and the start of school, make sure you have a valid travel signature on your I-20 and that your visa allows multiple entries. Coordinate with Bechtel International Center if you have any doubts about re-entering the US.

You do not need to attend any or all of these trips. Many international students attend just Tahoe, which is the most affordable and accessible option. Don't feel pressure to do everything.

Part III – On Arrival to the GSB

You'll be given a detailed schedule when you arrive on campus and check in, but trust us: Welcome Weekend and Week Zero will be **really, really busy**. Be sure to check GSB Digest to get updates over the summer about events that are planned for your Arrival Week.

It's critical to get all moving-in tasks done before Welcome Weekend starts. Based on our experience, we recommend prioritizing the following to-do items.

1. Campus and GSB Maps

First and foremost, get a map of campus. Some sources:

- [Google Maps at Stanford](#) works quite well.
- Here's a [searchable version](#).
- You can also get a hardcopy at [Tresidder Memorial Union](#) when you get your Stanford ID or at the MBA or MSx Check-In stations.
- Get a digital map of the GSB to get to know your way around the C, P, M, G, N, E classrooms. You will also get a hard copy at the MBA or MSx Check-In stations.

2. Transportation on Campus

There are various transportation means once you get on campus:

- Bike – Useful for getting around on campus (see the [Getting a Bike](#) section below for more information). If you are sceptical of the upfront investment, the front desk at the Schwab Residential Center also lends out good high-quality bikes to GSB students for free for a period of four hours at a time.
- Car – Useful for getting around off campus and for grocery shopping (See the [Getting a Car and Car Insurance](#) section below for more information).
- Uber/Lyft – Smartphone apps that let you call a driver to your spot and pay online. Make sure to

download them, you will be using them a lot! Ridesharing options are also available within these apps: you may pick up / drop off other people along the way, resulting in a cheaper ride.

- Marguerite Shuttle – Stanford’s free bus service. Just hop on, no id, cards, or anything required! Runs from campus to and from the Palo Alto Caltrain (which goes to San Francisco and San Jose). Some routes are useful for grocery shopping. For maps and schedules see [Shuttle Lines and Schedules | Transportation](#)
 - Pro-tip: Use the Y line of the Marguerite to get from the Caltrain Palo Alto stop to the GSB, and the X line to get from the GSB to the Caltrain
- Zipcar – an on-demand car sharing service. There are abundant ZipCar parking spaces on campus (and near the GSB) and cars generally available there. To use it, register as a member (\$35 annual fee for the first year), reserve a car online or by phone, use your mobile phone app to enter the car, and drive away. Rates start at \$10-20 per hour, including gas and insurance. Return the car to the same location where you picked it up. Zipcar works on an international license (though California law requires you get a local driver’s license. See relevant section below). For more information go to [Zipcar at Stanford](#)
- 5Sure: Useful if you are out studying / partying / working till late at night and don’t want to walk from end of the campus to another: [5-SURE Safe Rides | Cardinal at Work](#). Note that 5-SURE does **not** operate during Summer, Winter, Spring Breaks, and Finals weeks.
“The free service provides transportation to and from a variety of campus locations, including work locations, parties/events, sporting events, campus residences, libraries and other Stanford campus buildings from from 8:00 p.m. to 2:00 a.m. (Last call at 1:45 a.m) seven days a week”
- DISGO: If you are unfortunately injured, Stanford Disgo (<https://transportation.stanford.edu/disgo>) offers two golf cart services- one is a more long term one where you are assigned a golf cart and can drive it around yourself (more wait times to get this + less likely), the other is more of a golf-cart uber service where you can either call about 10-20 minutes in advance and have a golf cart pick you up + drop you off elsewhere on campus. You need to fill a form and be approved to be able to use this service.

3. Setting Up the Internet and Other IT Resources

3.1 Where to get Technical Assistance

Generally unknown facts: if you have any University IT related doubts or trouble, you can:

- Attend an IT support event in Week Zero
 - You can watch the MyGSB Digest for a link to set up an IT appointment during Week Zero, in which a technician will set up all of your devices for WiFi and printing. You might not believe it, but lots of us do seek help from IT support, because setting up is way more difficult than you think...
- Seek technical assistance at the Bass Center walk up IT help desk, located on the second floor of Bass, room B207. It is staffed from 10am-12:30pm and 2:30pm-5pm on Monday, Tuesday, Thursday and Friday.
- Submit a Help Desk Request. <https://helpsu.stanford.edu/helpsu/3.0/auth/helpsu-form> Call 650.725.HELP (650-725-4357).

- Check out the Digital solutions how-to page in MyGSB as well as an IT Tech letter which comes your way during / before Week zero

A note on Microsoft Office: Stanford provides Google Workspace (Gmail, Docs, Sheets, Slides, Drive) as the primary productivity suite. Microsoft Office 365 is also available to Stanford students for free. You can download it from <https://uit.stanford.edu/service/office365>. Both Mac and Windows versions are supported.

3.2 WiFi

There is WiFi almost everywhere on campus. All Wifi, including GSB Residence Wifi, can be registered for by following instructions found at:

<https://mygsb.stanford.edu/mba/it/how/network-registration>

- Stanford: this will be your standard Wifi.
- Stanford Visitor: this is a short term, low bandwidth network that does not require registration. Helpful for your first steps on campus.
- Eduroam: a secure, worldwide service allows students, researchers, and staff from other institutions that also use Eduroam to connect to the network. You can use it too with your Stanford login and is available throughout campus. We recommend trying this to figure out which wifi works for you the best - Stanford or Eduroam.

Smart Home Devices: If you plan to use smart home devices (Alexa, Google Home, smart lights, robot vacuums, smart pet feeders, etc.), be aware that Stanford's enterprise WiFi networks (Stanford and Eduroam) typically do not support IoT devices because they require individual authentication. You will likely need a personal WiFi hotspot or a travel router to create a separate network for these devices. Some students buy a small travel router (e.g., GL.iNet) for \$30-50 on Amazon that connects to Stanford WiFi and creates a private network for their smart devices.

3.3 Connect your Mobile Device to Email and Google Apps

Email is arguably your most important source of communication at the GSB. Yup, you will get a ton of it. The GSB uses the Google App suite of applications, which apart from email, includes Calendar, Drive, Docs, Sheets, Slides and others. You will use all of these extensively.

- Make sure you have email and calendar on your mobile device. It is **very** essential to keep track of your commitments and activities within the GSB community.
- Google has mobile apps for each of the applications that are quite convenient. The email app allows you to automatically filter mass emails (like Blast, see the [Student Communications Channels](#) section below) and can handle several different accounts at once (like your personal email).
- You can also configure your device's native apps. See this guide provided by Stanford Digital Solutions. <https://uit.stanford.edu/service/googleapps/emailcalendar/mobile>

3.4 Canvas

Much of GSB course communications happens through an online system called Canvas. Here you will have access to course digital materials, communications from professors, be able to form project groups, submit assignments, and take exams.

Make sure you familiarize yourself with the Canvas environment. Go to the Canvas website and login using your SUNet ID and password (the same as your email and everything Stanford).

<https://canvas.stanford.edu/>

3.5 Printing

Stanford works on a printing system called Cardinal Print. There are three ways to start printing:

1. [Download the universal Cardinal Print driver](#)
2. [Log in to the Cardinal Print Center](#) to upload documents
3. Send your attachment(s) via email to Cardinalprint@stanford.edu from your Stanford email address

All three options allow you to retrieve your output from any Cardinal Print device on campus by scanning your University ID card or logging in with your SUNet ID and password.

Note: the price to print are the following:

1. Color → \$0.05 per page
2. Black and White → \$0.008 per page

The University (through GSB) provides every student with a budget of \$100 for the year to take care of your printing needs.

3.6 Reserving a Study Room or Classroom

Simply log into [marrs](#) using your credentials and choose an available room. A lot of rooms including the Bass Center (the GSB library) study rooms can only be reserved 24 hours in advance, so plan accordingly.

4. Student Communications Channels

- **Blast:** We recommend signing up for “Blast,” which is a GSB student distribution list, i.e. a mailing list.
 - You will be notified how to sign up for Blast when fall term starts.
 - If you are a member, you can send an email to GSB-Blast-All@lists.stanford.edu (or the list for the respective MBA year/MSx) which will be received by everyone else who signed up to the list. This is a very popular way of getting all sorts of random communication across.
- Some rules about about Blast:

- Always include a **Blast Tax** when sending a Blast. This can be a funny image or gif. This is a way for us to self-monitor and ask ourselves if we really want to send this blast
- Be conscious of how many pictures you're attaching. The limit to a Blast email is 12,000 KB (usually this means a couple medium resolution pics). If your email doesn't go through, you'll get a notification and will have to resend (with some attachments/embedded pictures removed)
- Avoid accidentally replying-all by actually checking who you're replying to. Remove the blast list when replying.
- In order to avoid spamming students' email, a general rule of thumb when communicating with the class is to send a Blast only when the information is deemed valuable / relevant for at least 50% of the class; otherwise, use other methods of communication (WhatsApp, direct messaging, Slack, clubs mailing lists...). Generally, students use this list to advertise GSB events, BBLs ("brown bag lunch", lunch presentations/talks about a topic or with a special guest), parties, trips, sell stuff, and event tickets to other GSB students, post jobs, etc.
- It is helpful to create a rule to forward all e-mails from the Blast distribution list to a designated folder and avoid mixing important e-mails with many Blast mails. Gmail has a useful function that automatically separates your Primary mail from Forum mail, which is also replicated on their mobile app. If you do set up such rules, check your Blast folder frequently, since a lot of useful and time-sensitive information is shared over Blast.
- **Slack:** Slack is the communication tool among students at GSB.
- **WhatsApp:** Most popular for non-email communication. Traditionally, every year has a WhatsApp group of all internationals (we'll leave it up to your class to create one), and one group with the year above. We've created one for you:
<https://chat.whatsapp.com/KTXzxfBx2Pp9Ptv6wRTg3S>
- **Other campus distribution lists:**
 - Look out for other blast-like distributions lists. EV and Munger have their own. Several other campus wide organizations have weekly or monthly emails. For example the Stanford Energy Club, country student groups, etc.

5. Getting Your Stanford ID

5.1 Obtaining the ID Card

You will need your Stanford ID for various services such as printing, entering facilities and possibly for opening a bank account. If you live in the GSB residences, you can pick your ID at the front desk reception at Schwab. For students living in Escondido Village or Munger, your ID cards may be available for pick up at your residence front desk if you submitted your photo online prior to arrival. If not the above, you can pick up your card from the Stanford Card Office, located on the second floor of Tresidder

Memorial Union. Make sure you bring proof of identification (e.g. a passport) with you, and check the instructions posted on the [Photo Submission page](#) before you go. Submitting a photo in advance can save you time when picking up the card. Plan for several minutes up to half an hour at the Card Office, since there are typically many students picking up their cards at the beginning of each school year.

Dependents can also obtain a “Stanford Courtesy” ID card, which also grants them access to facilities around campus, including Bass Library and sports infrastructure. More information about the Stanford Affiliate card can be found on the SO website (you can help your SO get access to the SO website during Arrival week).

5.2 Buying stuff with your Stanford ID

- **Stanford CardPlan:** spend up to \$1,000 per quarter at various on-campus cafes (including Arbuckle cafeteria at Knight Management Center) as well as at the bookstore. Whatever you spend gets added to your Stanford bill. Apply via AXESS using the link in the “Student Financials Snapshot” section at the bottom of the landing page. For more info, see: [Stanford Card Plan \(SCP\) | Student Services](#)
- **Cardinal Dollars:** load money on your Stanford ID, and get 10% more value to spend. Some places where you can use Cardinal Dollars are: EVGR Marketplace, Market at Munger, EVGR Pub, Tressider (Starbucks, Panda Express, Jamba Juice, etc). For more info, see: [Cardinal Dollars | Stanford R&DE](#)
- **Meal Plan:** best value way to pay for meals at dining halls. Prepay and then deduct from your account. Arrillaga Family Dining Common, popular with GSBers, is a block from the GSB, half way between Schwab and Munger. For more info, see: <https://rde.stanford.edu/dining/graduate-and-post-doc-meal-plans>

6. Getting a Mobile Phone

6.1 General Tips

- **Make getting a US cell phone number a priority:** you will make lots of friends in Week 0 and will want to be contactable. You’ll also want to have access to your email and calendar at all times.
- We strongly recommend getting a smartphone if you happen not to have one.
- Get a data plan. Although WiFi is available all over campus, it’s not always stable and you will almost definitely want access to Google Maps and your email when off-campus. Since you are connected to WiFi most of the time, you don’t usually need much data capacity.
- There are Mobile carrier stores on University Avenue in Palo Alto and on El Camino Real near California Avenue. Make sure you take your passport.
- Stanford students receive discounts from AT&T, T-Mobile, and Verizon – see here for more info: [Discounts for Personal Mobile Device Plans | University IT](#)
- AT&T has historically had the best coverage on campus, as well as Verizon. T-Mobile is good but

patchy in some corners. Before selecting a service provider, make sure you have a signal in your room (e.g. get an American or MBA2 friend to check for you).

- If you don't have credit history in the US or don't have a Social Security Number (which you likely will not be able to get until your internship, refer to Bechtel International Center for advice), options for good plans are more limited or may require a deposit. **Past GSBers made groups of 4 (a "family") and took out family plans.**
 - Your options here are: Either join an existing family plan or one that an American classmate creates at the start of the year, or find a group of other internationals to jointly get a family plan. In the past years, most students who went down this route ended up with AT&T as they didn't require social security numbers.
- An alternative route is to get your individual contract with **US Mobile, Mint Mobile, or GoogleFi**, which have become more popular in the last year(s)

6.2 Cell-phone primer in the U.S. (How it all works here!)

There are three major carriers in the US:

- **Verizon:** Premium pricing, widely considered the best overall network coverage.
- **AT&T:** Strong coverage, competitive with Verizon. Historically popular with international students because they don't always require an SSN.
- **T-Mobile:** Good coverage in cities and most suburban areas, more affordable. Many students have reported patchy signal in certain campus buildings.

Note: Sprint no longer exists as a separate carrier. It merged with T-Mobile in 2020.

In addition to the three major carriers, there are Mobile Virtual Network Operators (MVNOs) that run on the same towers as the big carriers but at lower prices. The most popular MVNOs among GSB students are:

- **Google Fi:** Runs on T-Mobile's network. Easy to sign up online with no SSN required. Flexible plans. International coverage included. Can be set up before you even arrive in the US with an eSIM.
- **Mint Mobile:** Runs on T-Mobile's network. Very affordable prepaid plans (often \$15-30/month). No SSN required. Can buy a SIM on Amazon.

The most common approach among international students:

1. **Family Plans:** Groups of 4-5 students get a "family plan" on AT&T or T-Mobile, which brings the per-person cost down to \$30-50/month for unlimited talk, text, and data. In the past, most groups went with AT&T because they didn't require SSNs. One person in the group (ideally someone with a US bank account) opens the account, and others join as lines. Watch for announcements in the Slack channels and WhatsApp groups before school starts; people usually form groups in August.
2. **Individual prepaid/eSIM:** If you prefer independence, Google Fi or Mint Mobile are the easiest options. Both can be activated without an SSN, and Google Fi can be set up via eSIM before you leave your home country, giving you a working US number from the moment you land.

Pro tip: If your phone supports eSIM (most phones made after 2020 do), you can set up a US number through Google Fi or a similar provider before you even leave home. This is extremely valuable because you'll need a US number to set up bank accounts, sign up for Venmo, and exchange contacts during Week Zero. Before committing to a carrier, test the signal in your room (ask an MBA2 or American classmate to check for you, or use the eSIM trial approach).

6.3 Land Lines in University Housing

Some on-campus housing units may still have phone lines. Check with your specific housing front desk for current availability. Most students rely entirely on their mobile phones and WiFi calling. If you have a phone line (present in all GSB residences rooms), it can be used to dial free calls to anywhere in the world. You also get a free number to receive inbound calls. To make a call from this phone:

- **US:** 9 + 1 + full US number (e.g. 9-1-650-123-4567)
- **International:** 9 + 011+ country code + number
- **Emergency services:** call 9-911 (note: from your cell phone, just dial 911)

6.4 Useful Apps

Unsurprisingly, the GSB is a fairly tech-savvy place. Here are some commonly used phone apps:

- **Uber and Lyft:** You will use these constantly.
- **Venmo:** Essential for student-to-student payments (splitting dinner, event tickets, group trips). Note: Venmo requires a US phone number. There is a \$300 weekly spending limit initially; adding a US bank account and completing identity verification lifts this limit. You technically need an SSN to fully verify, but most international students have successfully completed verification without one. Also, note that Venmo works as an intermediary wallet and transferring funds to your bank account takes 2-3 days.
- **Zelle:** Another payment app, often built into US banking apps. Useful when you want to do direct instant bank-to-bank transfers.
- **Paypal:** another commonly used payment app.
- **WhatsApp, Slack:** Group messaging. The GSB class uses all of these. WhatsApp has become the primary tool for student communication at the GSB.
- **Yelp!:** Restaurant and services recommendations (hairdresser, dry cleaner, etc.)
- **Google Maps:** Navigation, public transit directions, and discovering restaurants/stores nearby.
- **Clipper:** Bay Area public transit card app (add to Apple/Google Wallet).
- **DoorDash, Uber Eats:** Food delivery.
- **Instacart:** Grocery delivery.
- **Stanford Mobile:** Contains your virtual ID card, events information, etc.

7. Setting Up Your House

Below is a list of some of the key stores around campus:

7.1 Furniture & Housewares

- IKEA (1700 East Bayshore Rd, East Palo Alto) - at the beginning of the academic year, delivery times can be much longer than usual and popular standard items for student dorms sold out, so you may have to be a little patient, try to go multiple times or order as early as you can.
- Walmart (600 Showers Dr, Mountain View)
- Target (555 Showers Dr, Mountain View)
- Note that you can also use their delivery service v/s visiting the store in-person.

Note: The GSB Residences and many other graduate housing options come semi-furnished. Check the RD&E website (<https://rde.stanford.edu>) for more details.

Loan Closet: Stanford's Loan Closet lends household items (kitchenware, small appliances, organizers) to students for free on a temporary basis (1-2 years), which is especially helpful during your first weeks. You can borrow a lot of items for a one-time registration fee of ~\$20 from the Loan Closet. Check with the GSB Residences front desk or R&DE for current availability and location. Additionally, at the beginning of each academic year, returning students and recent graduates often donate kitchenware, furniture, and other household items. There is typically a sale or giveaway event in the first week where you can pick up pots, pans, utensils, and other essentials for very little cost. Watch for announcements in GSB Digest / Slack / WhatsApp groups.

7.2 Electronics

- Best Buy (2460 E Charleston Rd, Mountain View)
- Apple Store (340 University Ave, Palo Alto, and 379 Stanford Shopping Center)
- Stanford Bookstore (they usually have promotional offers on certain Apple products at the start of the academic year + discounts on Apple retail prices)

7.3 Online Shopping

Really easy and widely used.

- Amazon (www.amazon.com). As a student (using your .edu address), you can get a free Amazon Prime account for six months which gives you free two-day shipping. As a side note, Amazon Prime comes with some great benefits, including a huge library of great TV shows and movies, many of which you can stream for free.
- SU Post (<http://supost.com>) is a site where people in Stanford can sell and buy used goods ranging from cars to furniture, bikes and TVs.

7.4 Receiving Packages

- If you live at the GSB Residences, the front desk will collect packages for you during the year. You can also process returns at the Residences.
- If you live in other university housing, you can send packages directly to your address. Sometimes private delivery services (UPS/Fedex, as opposed to the government's USPS) do not

have access to buildings or you may not want packages sitting in the hallways and potentially getting lost. In that case, you can use the optional services of the Graduate Housing Package Center. You can request a Unit address and from there you can register to have your packages automatically forwarded to your housing front desk. See

<https://rde.stanford.edu/studenthousing/mail-deliveries>

Amazon Returns: The most convenient return options near campus are the Whole Foods on Emerson Street in Palo Alto (Amazon accepts returns there via QR code, no box needed) and the nearest UPS Store. There are also Amazon Hub Lockers at various locations on and near campus. The GSB Residences mail room can process some returns; check with the front desk.

7.5 Requesting Repairs

If you find defects or malfunctions within your university housing, don't hesitate to submit a ServiceNow ticket. [Services Portal Home](#)

- Once the request is submitted, in the next few days (depending on the urgency of your request), a technician will come and fix whatever needs fixing.
- Examples are loose/creaky doors, clogged drains, faulty kitchens, broken windows, missing door stops, electrical issues, etc.
- This efficient Stanford service is included in your housing bill. You can submit a request at no additional cost.

Note: If you live at the GSB Residences, you can directly contact the Schwab reception front desk to get priority attention to your request.

7.6 TV

The GSB Residences come with a TV in each suite, equipped with cable service.

TV Streaming Services

Live TV streaming services use the Stanford WiFi network to connect to the Internet for which the TV needs to be registered on the network. We suggest consulting with your housing's staff for support with setting up your TV.

8. Eating

8.1 Groceries

On campus

- Supermarkets on campus are limited, rather small and expensive. Market at Munger (close to Munger residences) and EVGR Marketplace (at EVGR) are two options relatively close to the GSB. Most students who cook for themselves however opt for either off campus supermarkets or delivery options.

Off campus

- Trader Joe's (855 El Camino Real, Palo Alto): This small supermarket is close to campus and therefore a favorite for many GSBers.
- Costco Wholesale (1000 N Rengstorff Ave, Mountain View): This is generally the cheapest option, but as a wholesaler, be prepared to buy big quantities. You need to pay a membership fee to purchase here, for which you receive a Costco card. Many international students plan shopping trips with American students who hold a Costco membership card as a group of several people can shop at Costco using one card. They also have a home delivery option which can be more convenient.
- Walmart (600 Showers Dr, Mountain View): This US classic also has a groceries section. Cheap food in not so large quantities. Possibly not the best option for perishables.
- Target (555 Showers Dr, Mountain View): Another US classic with a groceries section.
- Safeway (325 Sharon Park Dr, Menlo Park or 525 El Camino Real, Menlo Park): A more complete offering of quality products.
- Whole Foods (774 Emerson St, Palo Alto or 4800 El Camino Real, Los Altos): This is generally considered the more upscale option High quality and wide variety but also higher prices.
- CVS Pharmacy (855 El Camino Real, Palo Alto): Close to campus option for prescription and OTC drugs, as well as general merchandise.
- Real Produce Market (501 Oxford Ave, Palo Alto): Another supermarket close to campus with a focus on fresh produce and international (Middle Eastern, European, and Indian) products.
- Apni Mandi (1111 W El Camino Real, Sunnyvale): Indian food supermarket chain with free chai and a cafe inside.
- 99 Ranch Market (1350 Grant Road, Mountain View): Asian food supermarket chain, with focus on Chinese foods but you could also find some good East/South-East Asian ingredients.

Delivery

- Instacart ([Instacart](#)): Popular option to order groceries.
- Amazon Fresh ([Amazon.com](#)): Amazon's grocery delivery option (includes delivery from Whole Foods as well).
- Wee! ([Weee!](#)): Online Asian supermarket.

8.2 On Campus Dining

- There are multiple dining halls on campus -
 - Arrillaga Family Dining Commons, popular with GSBers, is a block from the GSB, half way between GSB Residences and Munger. Wilbur Dining and Stern Dining, which are slightly further away than Arrillaga, are also popular with GSBers.
 - Meal Plan: best value way to pay for meals at the dining halls. Prepay for a block of meals which are then deducted from your account per use. Can be used at any dining hall on campus. Any unused amount may be eligible for a refund at the end of the academic year.
 - For more info, see: [Stanford Dining, Hospitality and Auxiliaries](#)

- There are many other dining options on campus. Some of our favorites:
 - Coupa Café: Decent coffee and good salads, paninis and arepas. Open fairly late and on weekends during term time. Three locations on campus including one at the Knight Management Center. You can pre-order online and set a pickup time, great for avoiding lines.
Note: Recommended to get a Coupa Café account to receive seasonal promotions and offers like -a \$5 coupon for every \$50 spent.
 - Arbuckle Dining Pavilion: At the heart of the Knight Management Center, you will most certainly have many lunch conversations with classmates there. Wide international buffet offering and prepared dishes. The salad bar is well known for its low cost/nutrition ratio. Open only for breakfast and lunch.
 - Jimmy V's Sports Cafe: Quick buffet lunches and snacks. In the Arrillaga Family Sports Center and across Campus Drive from the GSB (behind Bass Library), it's a great alternative to Arbuckle.
 - Axe & Palm: good burgers and milkshakes, open very late, popular. Located in the Old Union building, in front of the Stanford bookstore and next to Tresidder Memorial Union on the White Plaza.
 - CoHo: Good food, very popular, long hours. Located in Tresidder Memorial Union, has live music in the evenings - the quintessential cafe experience within Stanford.
 - Ray's Grill: Graduate student pub open long hours and on weekends. Located between Escondido Village and EV South. Mexican and Asian food, nothing special but a good place to go if you want to avoid undergraduates and very convenient if you live in Escondido Village. Also a good alternative for viewing sports.
 - Union Square: Located in the Tresidder Memorial Union, this food court houses popular fast food options like Subway, Panda Express (American Chinese food), and Starbucks.
 - For a full list of on-campus dining locations go here: [Stanford Dining, Hospitality and Auxiliaries](#)

8.3. Delivery

- DoorDash ([DoorDash](#)): A popular platform for food delivery.
- Grubhub ([Grubhub](#)): Another popular food delivery platform.
- Ekatree ([Ekatree](#)): Relatively newer option. Reduced delivery fees but fixed delivery times, specific delivery locations across campus and limited restaurant options to choose from.

8.4. Tipping in the US

Tipping is a deeply embedded part of US culture and is expected in many situations. As an international student, this may be new to you. Here is a practical guide:

- **Restaurants (sit-down, table service):** 18-20% of the pre-tax bill. This is not optional. Servers in the US earn very low base wages and depend on tips for their income. Most receipts will suggest tip amounts or percentages. When dining in a group, check whether a gratuity has already been added (common for groups of 6+).

- **Coffee shops/fast-casual counters:** Optional, but \$1-2 or 10-15% is appreciated. Most POS terminals will prompt you for a tip; it is fine to select "No tip" at a counter where you are just picking up a drink.
- **Uber/Lyft:** 10-15% is typical. You can tip through the app after the ride.
- **Food delivery (DoorDash, Uber Eats):** \$3-5 minimum, or 15-20% for larger orders.
- **Hair salons/barbers:** 15-20% of the service cost.
- **Hotels:** \$2-5/night for housekeeping (left on the nightstand), \$1-2/bag for bellhops.
- **Movers/furniture delivery:** \$10-20 per person for large jobs.
- **Taxis:** 15-20%.

When in doubt, 15-20% is the safe default for any service involving a human doing something for you. Tipping is done after service is rendered and is typically added on top of the listed price.

9. Opening a Bank Account

It is useful to have a bank account that you can wire money in from abroad, receive loan funds and Venmo payments, access cash from ATMs, pay debit (some places like gas stations and some online stores don't take foreign cards), and other transactions. It may also be a good idea to take out a credit card and start building a US credit history if you plan to stay for longer.

9.1 Banks On or Near Campus

Below are some options that GSB students have used in the past, but be sure to do your own homework.

- Stanford Federal Credit Union: [Tresidder Memorial Union](#), second floor or [694 Pampus Lane](#) right near Escondido Village.
 - There are multiple benefits to opening an account here. Since you don't have credit history and/or income, some banks won't give you a credit card. SFCU will give you a Debit card right away and a guaranteed credit card.
 - You can begin this process **virtually**. Open a checking account. If you have received financial aid, mail them your financial aid award letter.
 - Once you are here, continue the process in person. Indicate to the bank official that you want a credit card and present the fellowship as proof income. The Stanford Federal Credit Union is used to seeing this document and consider it as proof of income. If you have no financial aid award, still ask for a credit card! They are pretty open. Also make sure to bring your passport, a proof of address (which is the letter you have from R&D on Axxess) and ideally your student ID to show you go to Stanford.
 - They also offer a **"refer a friend, both get \$50 program"** - let us know if you want us to refer you.
- Wells Fargo Bank: Tresidder Memorial Union second floor
- Citibank: [250 University Ave, Palo Alto](#) or [2401 El Camino Real, Palo Alto](#). In the past, they have provided credit cards to students without a credit history. Also convenient for transferring funds from abroad if you are already a client back home.
- Chase: [855 El Camino Real, Bldg 2, Palo Alto](#).

- Bank of America: [3000 El Camino Real, Palo Alto](#) (near California Avenue). BoA also has an ATM on campus at Tresidder Union.

Before you make a visit to open an account, make sure you have all necessary documents with you to open an account. Note that you will likely need your passport, I-20 or DS-2019, Stanford ID and a proof of address (e.g. a piece of mail or a bill addressed to you, or you can ask for a letter from your housing front desk, or the letter from RD&E that you have in Axxess).

9.2 Some Handy Tips

- Some banks are on/near campus which is useful for having ATMs handy, others are more widespread nationally and have ATMs further afield. Some offer very cheap debit card options, others are willing to give you a credit card without a credit history. Plans and benefits vary widely and change all the time.
- Many students decide to set up a US bank account in their home country before arriving with banks with operations in the home country and US (e.g. HSBC, Citibank). Since the situation and fees vary by country, ask current and graduating students from your country for detailed information.
- Also note that it is difficult for International Students to obtain a credit card in the US unless you have a credit history (or open a US account with your existing bank)
- However, keep in mind that you can get a debit card at the banks listed above, and they work fine at most stores and online shopping sites that accept credit cards.

9.3 Credit Cards and Credit History

It is difficult for international students to obtain a credit card in the US, but you should consider doing so as soon as you can.

- This is not just to help you get access to credit / help with your cashflows
- Rather, this is primarily because having a good credit score will be critical in many situations after you graduate (e.g., landlords might check your credit before you can sign a lease), and it will take years to build a good credit score. More info [here](#) on why building out your credit history is important.
- You will need a social security number (which you will get when you start working in the US) before you can (generally) open a credit card in the US.
- As you will have no credit history, there are some ways to get an 'entry-level' credit card:
 - o **Apply to a credit card with the Stanford Federal Credit Union (recommended, see above).**
 - o Open a credit card with your US bank after you open your checking account there. As the bank has your savings, they might find you less risky of a customer.
 - o If you recently had a corporate credit card in your home country (e.g., American Express) and the statements are in your name, you can try to use them as proof of credit history and get a nicer credit card (No guarantee of success!)

9.4 Payment Methods in the US

Direct deposits are really uncommon in the US. Venmo or Zelle are extremely used for student-to-student payments: see the Useful Apps section within the [Getting a Mobile Phone](#) section above.

A checkbook might be useful to make large payments (e.g. rent if you live off-campus, or if you have a family and have to deal with other non Stanford agencies).

Credit and debit cards are used very frequently in the US instead of cash: it's perfectly acceptable to pay for a coffee using your credit card. Also note that gas station automatic dispensers and some online stores do not take foreign cards.

9.5 Transferring Money from Your Home Country

You will need to move money from your home country to your US bank account for tuition, rent, and living expenses. Traditional bank wire transfers work but are expensive (\$25-50 per transfer, plus unfavorable exchange rates that can cost you an additional 1-3%).

Most international students use **Wise** (formerly TransferWise) for international money transfers. Wise uses the mid-market exchange rate (the same rate you see on Google) and charges a small transparent fee, typically saving you significantly compared to bank wires. Key facts:

- You can sign up at wise.com before you arrive.
- Wise lets you hold multiple currencies, convert between them, and send money to US bank accounts via local transfer (no SWIFT fees).
- Most transfers arrive within 1-2 business days; many arrive within hours.
- You can also get a Wise debit card that works in the US, which can be useful as a backup before your US bank card arrives.

Other options include Remitly and OFX, but Wise is generally the most popular among students.

10. Getting a Bike / E-scooters

For those of you not living in GSB Residences (e.g. EV, Munger, other campus residence, or off campus), or if you plan to take classes in other departments at Stanford, having a bike is extremely useful to get around (Stanford campus is huge!). It's also useful for people without cars – there are grocery stores, pharmacies and restaurants all within biking distance of campus.

Even if you don't live in the GSB residences, as long as you are a GSB student, you can go to the Schwab reception front desk and borrow a bike for up to four hours at a time at no cost!

The Parking & Transportation Services has a lot of information about biking on-campus on their website: [Bicycle | Stanford Transportation](#). The most important thing to remember is DON'T DRINK AND BIKE. It's illegal and you **risk losing your visa**. Also, don't drive through stop-signs, it's an easy way to get a

ticket and be forced to take an all-day bike safety course.

10.1 Places You Can Purchase a Bike

- Your own network. Contact recent alums etc. through your own networks, country/region Stanford distribution lists, or by signing up to the GSB e-mail distribution list (a.k.a. Blast). See the [Student Communications Channels](#) section.
- Slack. Follow the all-buy-sell channel. Students sell bikes (and other stuff too) at the end of the year. Try reaching out and you could probably buy your bike even before arriving to campus.
- SU Post (<http://supost.com/>) for second hand bikes, usually can be picked up from somewhere on campus.
- Craigslist ([Craigslist](#)) is also a common option
- Campus Bike Shop: [Campus Bike Shop](#). Located in the Tresidder Memorial Union. They sell used bikes and all kinds of accessories like locks and helmets. Some of the staff members also sell second hand bikes as a side hustle (for less).
- Campus Bike Sales (hosted by Public Safety): [Bicycle Sale - Stanford Department of Public Safety](#). There are usually sales in November and April, and you can buy a bike for only \$40.
- Other nearby bike shops and their addresses are listed here: [Buy, Sell, or Rent a Bike | Transportation](#)

10.2 General Tips

- Buy a U-lock! There are a lot of bike thefts on campus and cable locks aren't safe. When locking your bike, make sure you lock the frame of the bike and not just the tire.
- Also, get a helmet to be safe. Accidents are very common on campus, with lots of distracted students riding along in many directions. By coming to Stanford you are investing a lot in your mind... don't let it hit the pavement.
- You must have lights when riding after dark. You get free lights when you register your bike.
- Get your bike registered – (a) because it's compulsory and (b) because it's your only chance of recovering your bike if stolen.
[Register a Bike Online | Stanford Transportation](#) - Bikes are subject to many of the same rules as cars in addition to specific rules for bikers.
- Police sometimes stop and fine bikers around the GSB for not stopping at the stop signs or not using their headlights after dark.

10.3 Electric Scooters

Electric scooters (e-scooters) have become very popular for the commute from EV, EVGR, and Munger to the GSB. They fold up, are lighter than bikes, and don't require a U-lock. Popular models include the Segway Ninebot and Xiaomi Mi Electric Scooter, both available on Amazon for \$300-500.

A few things to keep in mind:

- Unlike bikes, e-scooters are harder to lock outside securely. Some students bring their scooters into

classrooms (folded and placed under/beside their desk). This is generally tolerated but check with your professor.

- California law requires e-scooter riders to wear helmets (if under 18, but recommended for everyone) and follow the same road rules as bikes.
- E-scooters are great for flat campus terrain. If you plan to ride to destinations with hills (e.g., off-campus), consider battery range.

11. Getting a Driver's License or State ID

11.1 Why It May be Important to Get a California Driver's License

- **If you can, we recommend getting a California Driver's license as soon as possible.** In the US, a driver's license is the primary source of ID. Not only will it let you drive, it will also allow you to get into bars / pubs without carrying (and risk losing) your passport. Yet this ID role also makes it a little harder for foreigners to obtain and makes the process significantly longer because of administrative checks ([California Driver's License | Bechtel International Center](#)).
- Even if you don't get a driver's license, consider getting a California Photo ID from the DMV anyway which serves a similar role.
(<https://www.dmv.ca.gov/portal/dmv/detail/idinfo/idcard>)
- Technically California law only allows you to use your foreign driver's license for a maximum of 10 days if you are becoming a "resident" (loosely defined for these purposes). International Driving Permits are not recognized under California law (those issued under the Convention on Road Traffic, United Nations, Geneva 1949).
- Having a California driver's license will also make your car insurance cheaper.
- **NEVER EVER drink and drive (or ride a bike) in the US – if caught you risk losing your visa.** Also, the fines are really high for not stopping fully at stop signs, speed limits, etc. This also refers to riding a bike on campus. The Stanford police regularly patrol the area around the GSB! If you are fined, make sure you pay on time.

11.2 How to Get a California Driver's License

You must go to the California Department of Motor Vehicles (DMV) to obtain a California license. The closest DMV office from campus is in Redwood City ([300 Brewster Ave](#)), but there are many to choose from. Review, pick and choose, you may find open appointment slots elsewhere.

Note that while you may set up your appointment with the DMV even before arriving on campus, you cannot get a state-issued ID until you have an active SEVIS record at the Bechtel International Center. Be sure to schedule your DMV appointment a few weeks after your "Maintaining Your Legal Status" session at Bechtel.

Once your SEVIS is activated, then you will then need to go to the DMV twice:

- On the first visit, you will submit documentation (see below), take a simple vision exam and take the traffic laws and sign test ([DMV checklist](#)):
 - No appointment is required, though recommended.

- You should present the required documents (on paper, print them!):
 - Take your passport (unexpired), a valid US Visa, I-20 or DS-2019, and I-94 (must be printed out).
 - Take two documents (e.g. bank statements, proof of residence (go to myHousing portal → My Requests → Housing verification letter)) as proof of address
 - Provide a Social Security Number (SSN) if you have one - this has been variable and dependent on the DMV officer. Some students got their Driving License with REAL ID without an SSN, whereas some students were asked for an SSN to get a REAL ID (they were able to get the Driving License without the REAL ID though) - this has been DMV officer dependent.
 - Complete application form DL/ID card application ([application form here](#)).
- You will have to pay a nonrefundable application fee (~\$45-50) in the office. There is an online option, but we recommend doing it in person (some students had experienced technical issues with the payment while doing it online).
- The traffic laws and sign test is taken on a computer in the office and is available in several languages. There are 36 questions on the test and you need at least 30 correct answers to pass (80%+). This number is collated from unofficial sources so we suggest you look up the latest data for your time as this is subject to change. You have three chances to pass and can retake it immediately. It includes regulatory and common sense questions.
 - You can review the relevant material in handbooks given for free at the DMV (also available in other languages), or download it here: [California Driver's Handbook](#)
 - We recommend you to invest 30-60 mins into studying for the theory test. There are lots of great YouTube videos to study as well. Each year, multiple students do fail this part. The test is computer-based, and you have to maneuver the language settings yourself.
- Once you pass the traffic laws and sign test, you will be given a temporary driver's permit, which only allows you to drive under the supervision of someone else with a valid (full) driver's license. The permit number will allow you to make an appointment for a behind-the-wheel-test (appointment required).
- On your second visit to the DMV, you will take the behind-the-wheel-test.
 - You need to take a car. You can use your own, rent a car (check if the renting agency allows using the car for a driving test. Zipcar explicitly disallows) or borrow a friend's car for the test. Whatever vehicle it is, just make sure that the car is registered in California and that you bring the car's registration and insurance card.
 - They REQUIRE someone with a valid California driver's license to accompany you, no way around this, don't even try, even if you have a valid driving license from your country (you only have a temporary driver's permit!).
 - The behind-the-wheel-test is quite strict, make sure you read the driver's handbook thoroughly to be clear on the regulation. But don't worry too much. Especially, if you have been driving before, the test is more to see whether you can adhere to "textbook-style driving". There are many good YouTube videos on this test.
 - This test is not required if you already have a driver's license from another US state.

- After successfully passing the behind-the-wheel-test you will be given a paper license while the plastic card is processed. This paper license is valid for 90 days.
 - If you are a foreigner, the DMV sends your application to a back office specialized in immigration matters which is why obtaining a card may take a bit longer. Most students receive their cards in 14 days to 1 month. If your card takes longer (extremely few cases, don't even worry about it), before your paper license expires, renew it by paying (another) visit to the DMV. Be sure to ask what the status of the application is. Sometimes they call the back office and get it pushed through.
 - The back office checks your immigration paperwork against government databases, including your I-94 (proof of last entry). If you leave and then reenter the US after you take the test but before the back office reviews your application, your submitted I-94 will have expired. There are odd reports that this has stalled applications before, but you will not be advised of this by the DMV. In doubt, visit the DMV.
- Your new California driver's license will be valid from the day you receive it until your academic program ends, as listed on your I-20 or DS-2019. If you extend your stay in the US, you will have to renew your license.

11.3 A Few General Tips

- **Very important:** Before applying for a license, wait 10 days after your SEVIS record has been registered/validated by Bechtel International Center. For F1 students, this can only be done after you have attended a *Maintaining Legal Status* session. All records are then validated by November 1, but you can request earlier validation by submitting an online request at the iCenter website. You can submit your request online at [California Driver's License | Bechtel International Center](#).
- Official information source from the DMV website: https://www.dmv.ca.gov/portal/dmv/?1dmy&urile=wcm:path:/dmv_content_en/dmv/dl/dl_info#two500
- We can highly recommend applying for a REAL ID instead of just a driver's license. The REAL ID allows you even to fly domestically within the US without you having to use your passport – very useful! The documents required to apply for a REAL ID are the same as for the regular driver's license, plus a second proof of residence (e.g. a letter by the GSB residences, your bank statement).
- There is usually a VERY long line at the DMV, even if you have an appointment (though it helps quite a bit). Assume you'll be there for 2-4 hours. Get there early and bring something to spend time with you. The DMV will not provide your fondest memories of the GSB experience, get it over soon.
- Schedule an online appointment through the DMV's website. Note, appointment slots are usually available several weeks into the future.
- Do not schedule an appointment, or plan to visit the DMV during Week 0 or Week 1. Try to do this during Arrival Week or wait until you have your class schedule to make an appointment. But don't stress if you don't get it done that early - some of us have not fully completed the process as we are writing this guide in May in our first year.

12. Getting a Car and Car Insurance

Buying a car is not a “must” item on the checklist – many first years get around Palo Alto without owning a car. However, if you don’t want to ask people for rides when you go out, go to the supermarket, if you plan on making frequent weekend trips, if you live far off campus, etc., you may consider getting a car.

Keep in mind that having a car on campus can be expensive. If you do want a car, it is best to look early since there will be recent alumni and current students selling their cars, and it will be useful to have your car for furniture shopping. You can buy a new car, but most students here buy used cars.

12.1 Not Buying a Car

Many students don’t buy a car, particularly in the first year. The campus is walkable and bike friendly. Services are nearby and abundant. The online economy is booming. Yet if you do need to move around, there are some alternatives. See section [2. Transportation](#)

12.2 Buying a Used Car

Please note that what we list for car shopping, insurance and paperwork, etc. below is not intended to be comprehensive. Make sure you do your own research! Also refer to the A-Z Guide provided by the Student Support team: <https://mygsb.stanford.edu/mba/welcome-mba-admits/arrival-life-gsb> (Please note that this link will be made available by the GSB closer the start date of classes).

Where to buy:

- Your own network. Contact recent alums etc. through your own networks, country/region Stanford distribution lists, or on Slack. See the [Student Communications Channels](#) section.
- Online
 - www.kbb.com. Great place to check what the average market price is for used cars.
 - www.cargurus.com
 - www.cars.com
 - <https://sfbay.craigslist.org/>. Lots of variety, but it's a wild market.
- Dealers
 - Often offer significant discounts on Labor Day (first Monday in September).

Mechanic Inspection

- You should definitely take the car to a mechanic for evaluation before buying.
- You can also use Carfax (www.carfax.com), an online registry that most reputable mechanic shops report to. See if the car has been in any accidents, has had major repairs and has completed required recalls if any. Other students may have a log-in.

Price Check

- Compare prices using www.kbb.com, www.cargurus.com or www.cars.com to ensure you’re not overpaying.

12.3 Administrative Paperwork

- For the official information, browse www.dmv.ca.gov, not the friendliest site, but has the official California Department of Motor Vehicles (DMV) information and appointment system.
- In particular see here: [How to Register Vehicles Purchased in Private Sales - California DMV](#)
- At the California Department of Motor Vehicles (the DMV):
 - Make an appointment at the DMV to register and title the vehicle in your name. You don't need to bring the seller along. You can go without an appointment, but be prepared to wait.
 - Pay the transfer and registration fees. It depends on several factors, but is usually ~10% of the value of the sale. To have a sense of the amount, use the DMV's registration fee calculator. <https://www.dmv.ca.gov/portal/dmv/detail/portal/feecalculatorweb>
- You must pay on your appointment day, be prepared to present the paperwork to transfer the title and also update the name on the registration.
- California certificate of title (Pink Slip) – if the Pink Slip does not have form fields for ownership transfer and odometer reading, you need form
- "REG 262" from the DMV
 - Bill of sale – <http://dmv.ca.gov/forms/reg/reg135.htm>
 - Statement of facts – completed by the buyer when the vehicle is a gift, a sale from a family member, you have a smog check exemption or other differentiating factors. https://www.dmv.ca.gov/portal/dmv/?1dmv&urile=wcm:path:/dmv_content_en/dmv/forms/reg/reg256.
 - Proof of insurance.

12.4 Insurance

You will need proof of insurance to register the car.. There are two types of insurance:

- Liability (3rd party): Covers the damage you cause in an accident to other cars and people.
- Car insurance: covers the damage to your car if you caused the accident.

Make sure you fully understand your insurance coverage. The law-mandated minimums are very low in California and will hardly cover you if you get into an accident. You can purchase insurance online (e.g. www.geico.com, www.aaa.com, getjerry.com) or through a broker (e.g. AIS). Geico has recently provided competitive rates, particularly for international students without a driving history in the US. In the past, Geico has accepted foreign driver's licenses as proof of driving experience under the expectation that you get a California driver's license "soon." Also, if you have records of old foreign driver's licenses which indicate how long you have been driving for, Geico may accept it as proof of experience in order to lower your premium. Scan old licenses before you come.

Electric Vehicles (EVs): If you are bringing or buying an EV, Stanford has charging stations on campus, but availability can be limited, especially at the mid-rises and EVGR. Check the specific charging infrastructure at your housing location before committing to an EV. For weekend trips to Tahoe, Yosemite, or Big Sur, range and charging stop planning become important. Most EV owners find it manageable, but it requires more planning than a gas car.

13. Getting a Parking Permit

If you get a car and will be parking on campus, purchase a parking permit for your car at Stanford Parking & Transportation Services.

- Parking spaces within campus are almost all marked by zone (eg. A, C, SO, EA, etc.). A permit will give you access to a specific zone. These are determined by your housing/commuter status, as well as your willingness to pay.
- Parking permits can cost from \$300 for a residential permit (SO, ES, etc.) and C commuter permits, up to \$1,000 per year for A commuter permits. Daily, monthly and 10 month periods are also available.
- Visitors can park in hourly metered spaces using the Parkmobile mobile app (US credit/debit card required).
- You cannot park your car on campus without the relevant zone permit, and can be charged up to several hundred dollars for a violation, so make sure to get a parking permit as soon as you move your car on campus!
- The type of parking permit you should get and the price depends on where you plan to park your car – e.g. if you live in Escondido Village, you will need an ES permit, Munger, you get an SO permit. Make sure to check the sign where you plan to park before going to get your permit. You can also check the necessary type of permit on the map link below.
- You're only allowed to keep one motorized vehicle on campus unless you're in couples or family housing.
- Enforcement:
 - "A", "C," and "shared" resident/commuter lots are enforced Monday-Friday, 6 a.m. to 4 p.m. This means that much available space frees up after hours and on weekends.
 - Resident Lots posted as 'EA', 'ES', 'SO', 'WE', 'SJ', and 'SH' parking are enforced 24/7.
 - Parking Meters are enforced 8:00 AM - 4:00 PM, Monday - Friday, (excl. holidays).
- Useful links:
 - Stanford Parking & Transportation Services Website.
 - More information on permits and all information on Parking @ Stanford can be found here: [Parking at Stanford | Transportation](#)

14. Career Matters

For understandable reasons, international students may have additional questions with regards to careers, such as pivoting to the U.S. or job search outside the U.S.. The Career Management Center (CMC) and International Committee have designed several programs specifically aimed at international students such as U.S. style networking workshop, global alumni connect, and international student panel, on top of broadly applicable newsletter and programs put together by relevant career clubs and CMC. Keep a lookout for these events after the Academic Adjustment Period ends!

CMC has two specific advisors, Sherice Torres and Deb Aliprandi, for international students. They focus on the U.S. visa and work approval process, job search in the U.S. as an international, and global job search. However, any role/function-focused CMC advisor should be able to give you tailored advice if you let them know you are international students. Regional clubs/associations (e.g., Europe club, MENA club, SABSA, ABSA) are another good resource if you are interested in a career in a specific region

While you will not have access to most career resources before the Academic Adjustment Period ends, you can still use the time to learn from your classmates' career paths and start reflecting and planning your goals. GSB has a very diverse community and chances are someone has been in the community/role/company/industry that you are interested in, so never hesitate to reach out!

15. Fitness, Sports, and Outdoors Facilities

Stanford has world-class sports and recreation facilities, and as a student with a valid SUID card, you have free access to most of them. Here is what you need to know:

Gym Access (Free with SUID):

- Arrillaga Center for Sports and Recreation is the main gym closest to the GSB. It has weight rooms, cardio equipment, basketball courts, an indoor track, and a pool.
- AOERC (Arrillaga Outdoor Education and Recreation Center) is another option with fitness equipment.
- You can access these facilities by swiping your Stanford ID. No additional membership is needed for basic gym use.
- Schwab Residential Center also has a small gym (enough for 4-5 people at once) with all the basics you need - treadmill, cable machine, bench, weights, leg press, etc.

Group Fitness Classes (Paid):

- Stanford Recreation and Wellness offers group fitness classes (yoga, spinning, HIIT, Pilates, etc.) through the "Cardinal Pass" program. These require a quarterly fee. Check <https://rec.stanford.edu/move/fitness> for current pricing and class schedules.
- There is also a Platinum Pass option that includes premium classes and F45 membership.

Intramural and Club Sports:

- Stanford has intramural leagues for soccer, basketball, volleyball, softball, and more. GSB students form teams every quarter. Watch for sign-ups on Slack and Blast.
- Club sports (rugby, cricket, sailing, climbing, etc.) are open to graduate students. See <https://stanfordclubsports.com/> for the full list.

Outdoor Recreation and Equipment Rentals:

- Stanford's Outdoor Recreation program rents camping gear, ski equipment, surfboards,

paddleboards, and more at very affordable rates through The Gear Hub. Great for Tahoe trips, Big Sur camping, and Santa Cruz surfing. See <https://rec.stanford.edu/adventure/equipment-rentals>.

- AOERC also has a fully fledged climbing wall which is quite popular among GSB students

Partner/SO Access:

- Partners with a Stanford Courtesy ID card can access recreational facilities. Check with RecWell for the current guest pass policy: <https://rec.stanford.edu/visit/membership/guest-passes>.

ClassPass and Off-Campus Options:

- Some students use ClassPass to access boutique fitness studios (Barry's, CorePower Yoga, etc.) in Palo Alto and the broader Bay Area. This is a personal expense but can be a nice complement to on-campus facilities.

16. Academic Preparation and Classroom Norms

Course Placement: For your first quarter, you will take core courses in Accounting, Finance, Organizational Behavior, and Operations (OSM). Before classes start, you will take placement exams (**for your second quarter core courses, not first**) that determine whether you are placed into Base, Accelerated, or Advanced levels for quantitative courses. If you have strong prior knowledge in a subject, you may be placed at a higher level. If you want to request a level change (up or down), there are two windows: one in early August and another on the first day of classes. You will need to justify your request. It is generally recommended to get into levels which you find comfortable so that you can be stress free!

Device-Free Classroom: The GSB has a device-free classroom policy for most first-year core classes. This means no laptops or phones during class. Not all professors allow taking notes on your tablet so we recommend going through each class' course policy / check with the professor on this. You will generally need to take handwritten notes.

Textbooks: Do not rush to buy textbooks before the first day of class. Wait until your professors confirm what is required. Some courses use digital platforms (e.g., MyLab Finance) that require a paid account. You can find almost all textbooks through the Stanford library's website: [Stanford Libraries](#)

If you prefer physical textbooks, options include the Stanford Bookstore (which may offer used copies), buying from MBA2s on the #all-buy-sell Slack channel or WhatsApp, and Amazon. In many courses, readings are provided digitally through Canvas.

AI in the Classroom: Policies on AI usage vary by professor and are evolving. Most professors allow AI for brainstorming and assignments, given that you properly cite AI usage in your work. Very few (rare) prohibit it entirely. Pay close attention to each course's honor code and AI policy statement at the beginning of the quarter.

Attendance: First-year core class attendance is mandatory. You are expected to attend every class session. Each course has its own policy on excused absences (typically 1-2 per quarter for documented reasons like

illness, family emergencies, or job interviews). Missing class for personal travel, weddings, or conferences is generally not excused during the first quarter. If you have a known conflict (e.g., a family wedding), speak with your professors early. After the first quarter, attendance policies vary by course.

17. Mental Health and Wellbeing

Moving to a new country, starting an intense academic program, and navigating a new social environment can be overwhelming. It is completely normal to feel stressed, homesick, or emotionally drained, especially during the first quarter. Here are the resources available to you:

- For any immediate mental health support or assistance, contact [Counseling and Psychological Services](#) (CAPS) at 650-723-3785 at any time (24/7). A clinician will be available to speak with you, assess your situation, and offer support and/or recommendations for follow-up.
- Dr. Tom Ellis and Dr. Liz Chaney are the embedded CAPS psychologists dedicated to GSB students. You can read about this resource [here](#) and schedule appointments with them by calling Vaden or emailing Dr. Ellis or Dr. Chaney directly at tsellis@stanford.edu or lchaney@stanford.edu if you are interested in a consultation.
- [TimelyCare Therapy](#): CAPS also offers students the opportunity to receive up to 12 free virtual therapy sessions with a therapist, paid for by CAPS. You can access this resource through the [TimelyCare App](#).
- **Your Peer Mentor:** You will be assigned a Peer Mentor (an MBA2) during Week Zero. They are there specifically to help you navigate the first-year experience.

The GSB culture is supportive, but the pace can be relentless. Build habits early: exercise, sleep, and stay connected with friends and family back home. It is okay to say no to events. You do not need to attend everything.

18. Partners and Significant Others (SOs)

If you are bringing a partner or spouse, here are the key things to know:

- **Stanford Courtesy ID:** Your partner can obtain a Stanford Courtesy (Affiliate) ID card, which grants access to campus facilities including libraries, gyms, and dining halls. Information about getting the Courtesy ID will be shared during Arrival Week. The SO website (accessible with your Stanford login) has detailed instructions.
- **SO Career Resources:** The GSB and Stanford broader community offer some career resources for partners. Information about partner career support is typically shared during Arrival Week. Ask the Student Support team for the latest (search myGSB for their latest contact details).
- **SO Community:** There is usually a WhatsApp group for SOs and partners. Ask during Arrival Week or on Slack to get added. Partners often form strong communities of their own.
- **Housing:** If you are living with a partner, you will likely be in EV (mid-rises or low-rises), EVGR, or off-campus housing. GSB Residences (Schwab) has limited couples housing. Indicate your housing preference early during the lottery.

- **Gym/Rec Access for Partners:** Partners with a Courtesy ID can access Stanford recreational facilities. Check RecWell's guest pass policy for the current details:
<https://rec.stanford.edu/visit/membership/guest-passes>.

Part IV – I am here. Now what?

Now that you have settled in the GSB and survived the first few weeks, below are some things you need to be mindful of being an international student.

1. Taxes (Winter / Spring quarter)

As an international student, you are required to file certain US tax forms even if you had no US income during the calendar year. Here is what you need to know:

1.1. Form 8843

This is Required for all F-1 and J-1 students, even with zero US income. Form 8843 is a simple informational form that tells the IRS you were present in the US as an exempt individual (student). You must file this form every year you are in the US on an F-1 or J-1 visa, regardless of whether you earned any income. It is not a tax return; it is a statement of your presence. The form is straightforward and takes about 15 minutes to fill out. You can download it from the IRS website:
<https://www.irs.gov/forms-pubs/about-form-8843>.

Sprintax (For students with US income, e.g., from summer internships): If you earned any US income (from an internship, CPT employment, scholarships/fellowships treated as taxable income, etc.), you will likely need to file a federal (and possibly state) tax return. As a non-resident alien, you cannot use standard tax software like TurboTax. You can use **Sprintax**, which is designed specifically for non-resident tax filing.

Stanford provides a Sprintax access code that significantly reduces the cost. Bechtel International Center publishes instructions for obtaining the access code each tax season:
<https://bechtel.stanford.edu/navigate-international-life/taxes/sprintax-software>.

1.2. Timeline

Tax filing season runs from January through April 15. You will typically receive your W-2 form (from any US employer) by late January, and then file your return.

1.3. Tips

- There are usually envelopes and stamps available at the Schwab Residences front desk if you need to mail any tax documents.
- Apart from Sprintax, there are other tax software options with some free features. However, Sprintax is the most reliable for non-resident filings.
- If your tax situation is complex (e.g., you have investment income, income from multiple countries, or tax treaty benefits to claim), consider consulting a tax professional. Stanford's VITA (Volunteer Income Tax Assistance) program sometimes offers free tax help, but verify that the volunteers are experienced with non-resident filings.
- Keep records of any income, tax documents (W-2, 1042-S, 1099), and your entry/exit dates for the US throughout the year. You will need these when filing.

2. Eligibility to work / earn \$\$\$ in the US

2.1. General Rule

International students on F-1 visas are not allowed to work in any form during the first three quarters of the MBA program (Autumn, Winter, Spring). This includes full-time work, part-time work, freelancing, consulting, paid referrals, or **ANY** activity that generates income. The earliest date you can start working is after the official end date of Spring Quarter (refer to the Stanford academic calendar for this date). Violating this rule jeopardizes your visa status.

2.2. Curricular Practical Training (CPT)

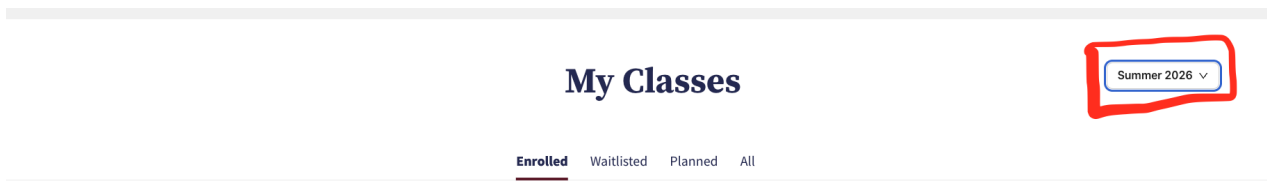
CPT is the authorization that allows F-1 students to work (e.g., summer internships) as part of their academic program. You will need CPT authorization before you can start any internship.

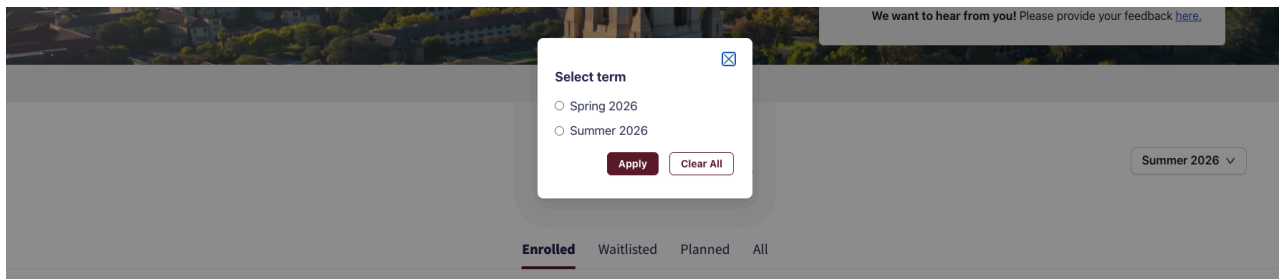
GSB official guide on CPT: this document will be updated every year. While we have linked the current guide available for 2026, you would receive a similar guide for 2027 on MyGSB. Refer to MyGSB - Career - International Resources to get the latest information.

 [2025-2026 CPT Step-by-Step Guide for MBA1s on F1 \(MyGSB\)](#)

Tips:

1. When enrolling in the GSBGEN 299 course on Axxess-Navigate Enrollment, your default quarter might not be Summer 202X. Remember to change the term on the right top corner of Navigate.





2. Start the CPT application process as soon as you have a confirmed internship offer. The process takes time, and you need the CPT-endorsed I-20 before you can apply for an SSN, and you need the SSN before your employer can process your payroll.

2.3. Social Security Number (SSN)

You will need an SSN to work in the US and to file taxes. Here is how to get one:

1. Eligibility: You can only apply for an SSN within one month of your employment start date. For example, if your internship starts on June 15, the earliest you should schedule an appointment is around May 15.
2. Apply online at <https://secure.ssa.gov/ossnap/public/landingOSSnap> or visit a Social Security Administration (SSA) office in person. Note that the SSN application website often runs into glitches and may enter a loop of verification or not proceeding to booking appointments. Sometimes the glitch self-resolves and you can proceed normally; people have reported it working better on mobile phones v/s desktop/laptops too. If the glitch persists, suggest not to wait and instead visit an SSA office in person as soon as possible.
3. Documents you will need: your passport, I-94 (printed from <https://i94.cbp.dhs.gov/>), CPT-endorsed I-20, and the SSN application form. There are often discretionary decisions made by SSA officers too. E.g., you may be asked to present a birth certificate and most of the time, your passport should be fine. If there are complications with your internship, e.g., doing 2 internships in one summer OR changing position or location from the original contract, suggest printing out all the related email correspondence as additional proof. We also recommend scheduling an advising appointment with Bechtel in case of any doubts since this is a sensitive topic and every case is unique and needs unique advice.
4. If you cannot find available appointment slots at the SSA office near you, try changing the zip code and checking multiple locations. The Redwood City, San Jose, and Mountain View offices sometimes have better availability than Palo Alto-area offices. People have also travelled to San Francisco, San Mateo or Richmond. This really depends on which office gives you the best timing that suits your plan.

5. If the online system does not work, you can try walking into an SSA office in person. This may or may not work depending on the office, but it is worth trying if you are running out of time.

Bechtel's full guide on SSN eligibility and application:

<https://bechtel.stanford.edu/navigate-international-life/social-security-number-ssn>

3. Housing During Academic Breaks

- **Thanksgiving Break (late November):** Classes pause for about a week. You can stay in your campus housing. Many students travel during this time.
- **Winter Break (mid-December to early January):** About 3 weeks. You can stay in your campus housing. Some students go home; others travel or go on Winter GSTs or stay on campus. The campus is quiet and dining options are limited.
- **Spring Break (March):** About 10-12 days. This is when the Spring GST typically takes place. You can stay in housing.
- **Summer:** Housing contracts for the GSB Residences (Schwab and JMac) typically end in June. If you need summer housing (e.g., for an internship in the Bay Area), you will need to arrange a sublease or apply for summer housing separately.

You do not need to vacate campus housing during Thanksgiving, winter, or spring breaks.

Other Questions? Need Different Help?

If this guide didn't answer all of your questions about coming to the GSB, there are many other sources of information available to you:

- MyGSB website!
- Admit Support: mba_admits@gsb.stanford.edu or +1-650-725-7963 (email preferred)
- Bechtel International Center's web page or advising hours. <https://bechtel.stanford.edu/>
- The MBA Student Support team. We can't stress enough how committed the staff there is to help you sort out any sort of "life" issues, be it family, academic, health, etc. Let them be your first stop if you are in need of advice and counsel. They know the University well and will orient you towards the relevant resources or may advocate on your behalf. In the first quarter, your Academic Advisor will also be a frequent point of contact. They are located on the second floor of the McClelland Building (above the "M" classrooms in the GSB). This is their website: <https://mygsb.stanford.edu/mba/student-life-home> - Here they provide a list of emergency support resources for life issues.
https://mygsb.stanford.edu/mba/student-life/emergency_support
- For MBA students, your Peer Mentor, whom you'll meet during Week Zero, and their "Ask an MBA2" Slack channel.
- Your friendly SA International Committee (refer to [Part I](#) for names and email addresses).
- The international students whatsapp group (see [Part I](#)). Feel free to drop a message here whenever

in doubt. There is a ~99% chance someone might have the same question as you!

In general, if you ask any question or support from any MBA2s or staff members, you should at least direct you to the persons who can help if they cannot help you themselves. GSB has a very supportive and tight-knit culture, so never hesitate to ask for help! Many GSB staff members chose their jobs because they like to interact with and support students, and all MBA2s were incoming students themselves too with a lot of anxieties and questions that were addressed with the help of the previous generation. We would love to pay it forward :)

Finally, good luck with the move and we look forward to seeing you on campus!